

GoCare Training Institute cPanel Deployment Guide

Step-by-step procedure for deploying the Laravel 12 + Filament 4 application from local WAMP to shared cPanel hosting.

Application	GoCare Training Institute
Framework	Laravel 12 · Filament 4 admin panel
PHP requirement	8.2 or newer
Database	MySQL / MariaDB
Source path	C:\wamp64\www\Gocare-laravel
Admin panel	/admin
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1 Before you start

Three issues in the current local configuration will break the live site or expose credentials. Resolve them before packaging anything.

BLOCKER — M-PESA CALLBACK URL IS EMPTY

`MPESA_ENV` is set to `live` but `MPESA_CALLBACK_URL` has no value. Safaricom requires an absolute, publicly reachable HTTPS URL to POST payment results to. The application already exposes the route `POST /mpesa/callback`, so the value must become:

```
MPESA_CALLBACK_URL=https://yourdomain.co.ke/mpesa/callback
```

Without it, STK push requests will be rejected or will never confirm, and payments will silently fail to reconcile.

BLOCKER — DEBUG MODE EXPOSES LIVE CREDENTIALS

The local file has `APP_ENV=local` and `APP_DEBUG=true`. In production, any unhandled error renders a stack trace containing environment variables — including your live M-Pesa consumer key, consumer secret and passkey. These must be `production` and `false` on the server.

CAUTION — STALE STORAGE FOLDER

`public/storage` currently exists as a real directory on the Windows copy rather than a symlink. If it is uploaded, `php artisan storage:link` will fail and uploaded media will not display. Exclude it from the archive and create the link on the server instead.

CREDENTIAL HYGIENE

The local `.env` holds **live** M-Pesa credentials and an Anthropic API key. If that file has ever been shared, emailed, or stored in a cloud-synced folder, rotate those keys in the Daraja portal and the Anthropic console before go-live. `.env` is correctly listed in `.gitignore`, so it is not in the repository history.

2 Build front-end assets

The compiled Vite bundle in `public/build` is excluded by `.gitignore` but is **required** in production — cPanel shared hosting has no Node.js runtime, so the build cannot be run on the server. Build locally and ship the output.

```
cd /c/wamp64/www/Gocare-laravel
npm ci
npm run build
composer install --no-dev --optimize-autoloader --classmap-authoritative
```

The `--no-dev` flag drops PHPUnit, Faker, Pail, Pint, Sail, Mockery and Collision from `vendor/`, which reduces the upload considerably and removes development tooling from the live server. Confirm that `public/build/manifest.json` and `public/build/assets/` exist before continuing.

3 Export the database

Dump the local `gocare` database:

```
mysqldump -u root -p gocare > gocare.sql
```

Then, in cPanel:

1. Open **MySQL® Databases** and create a new database. cPanel prefixes it with your account name, producing something like `cpaneluser_gocare`.
2. Create a database user with a strong password. It will likewise be prefixed: `cpaneluser_gouser`.
3. Under *Add User To Database*, attach the user and grant **ALL PRIVILEGES**.
4. Open **phpMyAdmin**, select the new database, and use the **Import** tab to upload `gocare.sql`.

IF THE IMPORT EXCEEDS THE UPLOAD LIMIT

phpMyAdmin on shared hosting often caps uploads at 50 MB. If the dump is larger, gzip it (`gzip gocare.sql`) and import the `.sql.gz` directly — phpMyAdmin decompresses it server-side. Failing that, upload the file via File Manager and import it from the cPanel Terminal with

```
mysql -u USER -p DBNAME < gocare.sql
```

4 Package the application

The project is roughly 380 MB once `node_modules` is excluded, with `public/` alone accounting for about 322 MB of images. Upload a **single archive** and extract it server-side. Transferring tens of thousands of individual files over FTP will take hours and frequently fails part-way.

From the project root:

```
zip -r gocare.zip . \
-x "node_modules/*" ".git/*" "tests/*" \
  "storage/logs/*" \
  "storage/framework/cache/data/*" \
  "storage/framework/sessions/*" \
  "storage/framework/views/*" \
  "public/storage/*" \
  ".env" "scratch_*" "*.result.cache" \
  "check-media-html.php" "render-media-debug.php"
```

What is excluded, and why

Path	Reason
<code>node_modules/</code>	54 MB of build-time dependencies. The compiled output in <code>public/build</code> is all the server needs.
<code>.git/</code>	Repository history has no place in a web root.
<code>tests/</code>	Not executed in production.
<code>storage/logs</code> , <code>framework/cache</code> , <code>sessions</code> , <code>views</code>	Local runtime artefacts. Laravel regenerates them; stale compiled views cause confusing errors. Keep the <i>directories</i> , discard the contents.
<code>public/storage/</code>	Must be a symlink created on the server, not a copied folder.
<code>.env</code>	Contains local database credentials and debug settings. A separate production file is written in step 7.
<code>scratch_*</code> , <code>check-media-html.php</code> , <code>render-media-debug.php</code>	Development scratch files. The two PHP debug scripts sit in the project root and should never be reachable from a live server.

Upload `gocare.zip` through **File Manager** and use its **Extract** action.

5 Choose a directory layout

Laravel expects the web server to serve only its `public/` directory. Everything else — `.env`, `vendor/`, `storage/`, application source — must sit outside the web root. Which of the two layouts below applies depends on whether your host lets you change the document root.

Option A — subdomain or addon domain (preferred)

Use this whenever the document root is editable, which is normally the case for subdomains and addon domains.

1. Extract the archive to `/home/USER/gocare-laravel` — outside `public_html`.
2. In **Domains**, set the domain's document root to `/home/USER/gocare-laravel/public`.

Nothing else changes. This is the cleanest arrangement: no file moves, no edited paths, and future updates are a straight overwrite.

Option B — primary domain with a fixed `public_html`

Many hosts lock the primary domain's document root to `public_html`. In that case:

1. Extract the archive to `/home/USER/gocare-laravel`.
2. Move the *contents* of `gocare-laravel/public/` — not the folder itself — into `public_html/`. This includes the hidden `.htaccess`; enable *Show Hidden Files* in File Manager settings first.

3. Edit `public_html/index.php` so both paths point back at the application root:

```
require __DIR__.'/../gocare-laravel/vendor/autoload.php';

$app = require_once __DIR__.'/../gocare-laravel/bootstrap/app.php';
```

The application root stays outside the web root, so `.env` and `vendor/` remain unreachable from a browser. The shipped `public/.htaccess` carries the rewrite rules and the Authorization-header handling that Filament's login needs — it must travel with the contents.

OPTION B CHANGES THE STORAGE SYMLINK TARGET

Under this layout `php artisan storage:link` creates the link at `gocare-laravel/public/storage`, which is no longer served by the web server. Step 8 gives the corrected command.

6 Set the PHP version and extensions

Open **MultiPHP Manager**, select the domain, and set PHP to **8.2** or **8.3**. The application requires `^8.2`; 8.4 also works where the host offers it. Anything below 8.2 will fail at `composer install` and at runtime.

Then open **Select PHP Version** (or *PHP Extensions*) and confirm the following are enabled:

Extension	Needed for
<code>pdo_mysql</code>	All database access
<code>mbstring</code> , <code>tokenizer</code> , <code>ctype</code> , <code>openssl</code>	Laravel framework core
<code>intl</code>	Filament — the admin panel will not boot without it
<code>gd</code>	Filament image handling and media uploads
<code>fileinfo</code>	Upload MIME-type validation
<code>curl</code>	M-Pesa Daraja API calls
<code>dom</code> , <code>xml</code> , <code>zip</code> , <code>bcmath</code>	Framework and package dependencies

While in the PHP settings, raise `upload_max_filesize` and `post_max_size` to at least `32M` if the admin panel is used to upload course images or documents, and set `max_execution_time` to `120`.

7 Create the production `.env`

Create the file directly on the server at the application root using File Manager, with *Show Hidden Files* enabled. Base it on your local values, changing everything listed below.

```
# --- Application ---
APP_NAME="GoCare Training Institute"
APP_ENV=production
APP_KEY=base64:...          # see note below
APP_DEBUG=false
APP_URL=https://yourdomain.co.ke
LOG_CHANNEL=stack
LOG_LEVEL=error

# --- Database (cPanel-prefixed names) ---
DB_CONNECTION=mysql
DB_HOST=127.0.0.1
DB_PORT=3306
DB_DATABASE=cpaneluser_gocare
DB_USERNAME=cpaneluser_gouser
DB_PASSWORD=your-database-password

# --- Drivers ---
SESSION_DRIVER=file
SESSION_LIFETIME=120
CACHE_STORE=file
QUEUE_CONNECTION=sync
FILESYSTEM_DISK=local
BROADCAST_CONNECTION=log

# --- Mail (cPanel email account) ---
MAIL_MAILER=smtp
MAIL_HOST=mail.yourdomain.co.ke
MAIL_PORT=587
MAIL_USERNAME=noreply@yourdomain.co.ke
MAIL_PASSWORD=your-mailbox-password
MAIL_ENCRYPTION=tls
MAIL_FROM_ADDRESS="noreply@yourdomain.co.ke"
MAIL_FROM_NAME="${APP_NAME}"
GOCARE_NOTIFICATION_EMAIL=admissions@yourdomain.co.ke

# --- M-Pesa Daraja (live) ---
MPESA_ENV=live
MPESA_CONSUMER_KEY=...
MPESA_CONSUMER_SECRET=...
MPESA_PASSKEY=...
MPESA_TYPE=till
MPESA_SHORTCODE=9373479
MPESA_TILL_NUMBER=7425170
MPESA_CALLBACK_URL=https://yourdomain.co.ke/mpesa/callback
```

Notes on specific values

- **APP_KEY** — reuse the existing local key if the imported database contains encrypted columns or existing user sessions. Generating a new one makes previously encrypted values unreadable. If nothing is encrypted, `php artisan key:generate` on the server is fine.
- **QUEUE_CONNECTION** — set to `sync`. Nothing in the application implements `ShouldQueue` and there are no job classes, so a queue worker would idle for no benefit. Shared hosting rarely permits long-running workers in any case. If queued work is added later, switch to `database` and add a cron job running `queue:work --stop-when-empty`.
- **ANTHROPIC_API_KEY** — omit it unless the site calls the Claude API at runtime. It appears in the local file but should not be shipped by default.
- **Redis and AWS blocks** — remove them. Shared cPanel has no Redis, and the S3 credentials are unset.
- **No scheduler cron is required.** `routes/console.php` defines only the stock `inspire` command, so `schedule:run` has nothing to do.

8 Run the setup commands

Use **cPanel** → **Terminal**, or SSH if it is enabled. From the application root:

```
cd ~/gocare-laravel

# Remove the Windows folder if it slipped into the archive
rm -rf public/storage

php artisan storage:link
php artisan migrate --force
php artisan config:cache
php artisan route:cache
php artisan view:cache
php artisan filament:optimize
```

`--force` is required because `APP_ENV` is `production`; without it, Artisan refuses to run migrations non-interactively.

OPTION B — CORRECTED STORAGE SYMLINK

If you used the primary-domain layout, the link created above points somewhere the web server does not serve. Replace it:

```
rm -f ~/gocare-laravel/public/storage
ln -s ~/gocare-laravel/storage/app/public ~/public_html/storage
```

NO TERMINAL ACCESS?

Some shared plans hide the Terminal. Use **Cron Jobs** as a one-shot runner: schedule the command a minute or two ahead, let it fire once, then delete the entry.

```
cd ~/gocare-laravel && /usr/local/bin/php artisan migrate --force
```

Check **Select PHP Version** for the exact CLI binary path — on many hosts it is

`/opt/cpanel/ea-php82/root/usr/bin/php` rather than `/usr/local/bin/php`. Using the wrong binary silently runs an unsupported PHP version.

AFTER CACHING CONFIGURATION

Once `config:cache` has run, edits to `.env` have **no effect** until you re-run it. Any time you change an environment value on the server, run `php artisan config:clear && php artisan config:cache`.

9 Set file permissions

```
find ~/gocare-laravel -type d -exec chmod 755 {} \;  
find ~/gocare-laravel -type f -exec chmod 644 {} \;  
chmod -R 775 ~/gocare-laravel/storage  
chmod -R 775 ~/gocare-laravel/bootstrap/cache  
chmod 600 ~/gocare-laravel/.env
```

Laravel writes logs, compiled views, sessions and cache files into `storage/` and `bootstrap/cache/`, which is why those two need group write. `.env` is restricted to the owner. Never set `777` on anything — many hosts refuse to execute PHP in world-writable directories, and it is an unnecessary exposure on a shared server.

10 Enable SSL and verify

Open **SSL/TLS Status** and run **AutoSSL** for the domain. This is not optional: Safaricom will not POST payment callbacks to a plain-HTTP endpoint, so M-Pesa cannot function without a valid certificate.

Post-deployment checklist

- ☐ **Homepage loads with full styling** at `https://yourdomain.co.ke`. Unstyled output means `public/build` was not uploaded — return to step 2.
- ☐ **Admin panel reachable** at `https://yourdomain.co.ke/admin` and login succeeds. A 500 here usually means the `intl` extension is missing.
- ☐ **Media uploads display**. Upload an image through the admin panel and confirm it renders on the public site — this exercises the `storage` symlink.
- ☐ **Application form submits** and writes a record, confirming database access and mail delivery.

- ☐ **Notification email arrives** at the address in `GOCCARE_NOTIFICATION_EMAIL`.
- ☐ **A test M-Pesa payment completes** and the callback updates the application record. Watch `storage/logs/laravel.log` during the attempt.
- ☐ `https://yourdomain.co.ke/.env` **returns 403 or 404**. If it returns the file contents, the layout is wrong — stop immediately, move the application root out of `public_html`, and rotate every credential in that file.
- ☐ **An invalid URL shows a plain 404**, not a Laravel stack trace. A trace means `APP_DEBUG` is still `true`.

11 Deploying future updates

Once the site is live, use this sequence for every change. Build assets locally first — the server still cannot run Vite.

```
php artisan down                # maintenance mode

# upload changed files, including a freshly built public/build

composer install --no-dev --optimize-autoloader
php artisan migrate --force
php artisan optimize:clear
php artisan optimize
php artisan filament:optimize

php artisan up
```

`optimize:clear` followed by `optimize` rebuilds the config, route and view caches in one pass. Skipping the clear step is the most common cause of "my change did not appear" after an update.

12 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause and fix
Blank white page or HTTP 500	Read <code>storage/logs/laravel.log</code> and the cPanel Errors page. Most often a permissions problem on <code>storage/</code> or <code>bootstrap/cache/</code> , or a missing PHP extension.
Page loads but has no CSS or JavaScript	<code>public/build</code> is missing or stale. Run <code>npm run build</code> locally and re-upload the whole <code>build</code> directory, including <code>manifest.json</code> .
Uploaded images return 404	The <code>storage</code> symlink is missing or points outside the document root. Recreate it per step 8, using the Option B command if the app sits beside <code>public_html</code> .
Every URL except the homepage returns 404	<code>.htaccess</code> was not uploaded — File Manager hides dotfiles by default. Enable <i>Show Hidden Files</i> and confirm it sits next to <code>index.php</code> in the document root.
Filament login redirects back to itself	Session directory not writable, or <code>APP_URL</code> does not match the actual scheme and host. Set it to the exact <code>https://</code> address and re-run <code>config:cache</code> .
<code>SQLSTATE[HY000] [1045] Access denied</code>	The database user was not added to the database, or the cPanel prefix is missing from <code>DB_DATABASE</code> / <code>DB_USERNAME</code> . Re-check in MySQL® Databases.
Environment change has no effect	Configuration is cached. Run <code>php artisan config:clear && php artisan config:cache</code> .
M-Pesa STK push sent but never confirms	<code>MPESA_CALLBACK_URL</code> is empty, uses HTTP, or points at a host without a valid certificate. It must be the absolute HTTPS URL of <code>/mpesa/callback</code> , and the certificate must be trusted.
<code>Class not found</code> after an update	Stale autoloader. Run <code>composer dump-autoload --optimize</code> .
File Manager extraction times out	The archive is too large for one pass. Split it — upload the application without <code>public/images</code> , extract, then upload the images as a second archive.